

Trust me, I remember... Or do I?

The reality about repressed memories & the memory wars

PSYC1003

**ACADEMIC
EDITION**

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The Memory Wars

Learning Outcomes

- **Examine** the development of the Memory Wars and its significance for legal psychology.
- **Analyse** the strengths and limitations of major false-memory research paradigms.
- **Critically evaluate** contemporary debates surrounding false memory implantation research.
- **Apply and justify** the use of memory research findings in legal decision-making and expert testimony

"Memory Wars"

a fierce, ongoing scientific and legal debate over whether traumatic memories can be unconsciously blocked (repressed) and later recovered, or if these recovered memories are often false creations planted by suggestive therapy

What Were the Memory Wars?

Two Opposing Positions

Recovered Memory Position

- Traumatic memories may become inaccessible
- Memories can later be recovered

False Memory Position

- Suggestive influences can create memories for events that never occurred

Elizabeth Loftus and Memory Reconstruction

Memory Is Not a Recording Device

Research demonstrated:

- Leading questions alter memory
- Post-event information influences recall
- Confidence is not a reliable indicator of accuracy
 - Memory is reconstructive

Landmark Contribution

Loftus proposed that memory is continuously reconstructed rather than faithfully retrieved.

The Original Lost in the Mall Study (1995)

Participants received:

✓ Three genuine childhood events

✗ One false childhood event

Becoming lost in a shopping mall at age five

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Result

**Approximately 25% of participants developed what
Researchers classified as a partial or full
false memory.**

Why Did Lost in the Mall Matter?

Legal Significance

If false autobiographical memories can be created:

- Witness testimony becomes vulnerable to suggestion
- Therapeutic practices become relevant
- Historical abuse allegations become more complex
- Expert testimony becomes increasingly important

But also:

Impact

What Counts as False Memory Research?

Pezdek & Lam (2007) Review of 198 false-memory studies:

Research Paradigm	Percentage
Whole-event implantation	13%
Misinformation studies	16%
DRM paradigm	41%
Recognition tasks	16%
Source monitoring	6%
Other	8%

Most researchers were studying memory errors, not full autobiographical false memories

Major False Memory Paradigms

Wade et al. (2007) Counterargument:

False memory is a broad construct. Different paradigms illuminate different mechanisms underlying memory distortion

Misinformation Effect

False details introduced after an event alter memory.

DRM Paradigm

People recall or recognise words that were never presented.

Source Monitoring

People confuse imagination, suggestion and experience.

Memory Implantation

Researchers attempt to create autobiographical memories for fictional events.

Source Monitoring Theory

Core Idea

People must determine whether mental experiences originated from:

- Direct experience
- Imagination
- Other people
- Photographs
- Media exposure

False Memories Occur When
Source attribution fails.

Lost in the Mall Again (2023)

A Modern Replication

Sample: BIGGER!

N = 123

Findings:

- **35% investigator-rated false memories**
- **14% self-reported false memories**
- **66% reported memory or belief**
- **Mock jurors often believed the memories were genuine**

Conclusion

The original effect was replicated.

Andrews & Brewin (2024)

A Re-analysis of the Replication

They coded six core details:

1. Shop
2. Being lost
3. Age

4. Crying
5. Elderly woman
6. Reunion with family

Key Finding

Participants classified as having false memories recalled surprisingly few suggested details.

Average explicit recall: **1.47 of 6 details**

The Central Critique

Potentially True Memories

Andrews & Brewin identified:

- Similar genuine experiences
- Being lost elsewhere
- Repeated childhood incidents

Approximately half of the false-memory cases appeared to contain potentially genuine memories.

Wade et al. (2025)

Memory is naturally reconstructive.

False memories should not be expected to contain only false elements.

All autobiographical memories combine:

- Episodic fragments
- Knowledge
- Imagination
- Inference

Proof of Principle Argument

Even low rates demonstrate that
false autobiographical memories are possible.

Brewin & Andrews (2025)

Continuing Criticisms

Legal Concern

Some expert witnesses may exaggerate:

- False-memory rates
- Similarities to therapy
- Generalisability to abuse cases

Recommendation

Greater precision and open science

Implications for Legal Psychology

Broad Areas of Agreement

- ✓ False memories exist
- ✓ Memory is reconstructive
- ✓ Suggestion can influence memory

Continuing Areas of Disagreement

- ✗ How common false memories are
- ✗ What qualifies as a false memory
- ✗ How laboratory findings relate to abuse allegations
- ✗ How experts should communicate evidence in court

The modern Memory Wars are not about whether false memories exist.

They are about how they should be measured and interpreted